INQUIRY INTO ALL ASPECTS OF THE CONDUCT OF 2025 FEDERAL ELECTION

Submitter details

Name & date	[redacted], submitted 26 September 2025
Federal electorate	Chisholm, Victoria
Role in 2025 federal election	Candidate [redacted] Achieved 6% of ordinary primary vote in 6 weeks campaign
Pre-poll booths	My direct observations and lived experiences come from pre-poll booths at Ashwood, Ashburton, Mulgrave, Malvern and Oakleigh. Some problems noted were shared with me from fellow volunteer campaigners.
Role context	This was my first experience: • as a [redacted] Candidate • at an election campaign (have never been involved in politics before) • on a pre-polling booth (having been a postal voter for over 25 years)
Reason for submission	I wish to see meaningful improvements made to the way federal elections are conducted. I believe simple changes can be made to further safeguard our democracy, and make voting easier and more welcoming for voters. Being involved in an election process for the first time was a rude shock to me. I was disgusted and offended with many aspects of the conduct of the election. If what I experienced in 2025 is the accepted standard of conduct, I would not recommend that other future potential candidates or volunteers directly engage in the electoral process.

STRUCTURE of SUBMISSION

Observations/Problems & Impacts	Page 2 – 4
References	Page 5
Example Photos	Page 5
Suggested Solutions	Page 6 - 7

Observations/Problems & Impacts

Topic from Terms of Reference	Observations / Problems	Impacts
Aggressive conduct **Deliberate obstruction** **Intimidating behaviours**	a) There was an intimidating, overly assertive and overwhelming path voters had to walk through to access a polling booth. Photos on page 5 show the 'corridors of coercion' at Malvern and Ashburton, and the 'hill of harassment' at Ashwood. When no queues were present, Mulgrave booth access could be via three paths, which could result in voters being 'swarmed' as they got out of cars. (On a good note, Oakleigh appeared to be more orderly and voter-centric.) b) I heard overly aggressive and negative/personally attacking slogans yelled at voters by [redacted] campaigners. These chants and slogans could be heard within 6m of the entrance of the polling booth. c) I experienced an intimidating bullying incident at Ashburton. While texting my husband, a [redacted] girl accused me of photographing her and uploading to a chat group. A large [redacted] man approached very closely and learned over me repeating the accusation. I denied it and showed him my phone. Fortunately for me, the man got involved in an argument with others and I quickly moved away. d) On election day at Brentwood, my son experienced [redacted] music. He saw [redacted] campaigners quietly move a speaker to the edge of the 6m 'exclusion zone' and play (assumed AI generated) slogan-laden music. This music could be heard within 6m of the entrance of the polling booth [1].	a) Some voters openly expressed their displeasure with having to 'run the gauntlet'. Some voters appeared distressed and tried to hide themselves. Some voters swore at approaching campaigners. I felt very bad for voters who were forced to walk through such an unwelcoming environment. I chatted to a [redacted] campaigner about my concerns for voters at the time, and his comment was 'some people like the theatre'. My question was "theatre for what purpose and at what cost?" He had no answer! b) Breach of s340 of the Electoral Act. Increased and active tension between campaigners e.g. deliberately covering corflutes, competing in 'slogan-offs', getting into arguments. c) I was personally very shaken and intimidated by the event. Witnesses were upset at the incident. My two volunteers came to support me and expressed their concerns. A [redacted] party candidate and his father who witnessed this event spoke to me several times later to check I was OK. The impact of witnessing such intimidating behaviours cannot be underestimated, since it has the potential to increased fear, defensiveness and anger amongst campaigners. Emotions are contagious and things can escalate quickly. d) Breach of s340 of the Electoral Act. This was irritating and upsetting to my 20yo son who was volunteering in his first election campaign. He was shocked and disgusted with such blatant disrespect. The music was also likely to be annoying to voters.

Safety and security	During the campaign, I discussed the above types of unpleasant behaviour experienced on pre-poll with AEC officials, our volunteer team, other campaigners, plus other candidates in Chisholm. Unfortunately, AEC appear powerless to manage or address behavioural issues beyond 6m of the entrance of a polling booth. I was informed that police had been called at Malvern at a time when our volunteers were present. My husband (volunteering in his first election campaign) witnessed an ugly incident at Mulgrave. He made an official written statement in support of an AEC official who was disciplined by AEC. The official was trying to protect voters and volunteers from intimidatory and bullying behaviour by a [redacted] volunteer. The official was disciplined on the basis of an edited video social media post accusing assault.	It was very un-nerving to experience these types of disgraceful conduct, and to learn that there were more serious things happening in other electorates [2]. This was scary at the time, and I was worried about what might happen in Chisholm (fortunately, nothing much escalated). The above, and since reported behaviours, of abuse [3] are unacceptable.
Universal voter access	Ashburton appeared to have a lack of parking for voters (taken up by campaigners). There were trip hazards with tree roots at the step between car park and 'corridor of coercion'. There appeared to be a poor layout, queue control and infrequent external monitoring of entry to booth from AEC. At times it was not obvious where the boundary mark was for 6m of the entrance of the polling booth.	Some voters with walking frames had difficulty accessing the Ashburton polling booth. This situation was often exploited by mostly [redacted] who saw an opportunity to 'assist' by swarming, hence preventing the voter having contact with other campaigners. Given it was not always obvious where and how to queue, voters could become confused. At times this increased tension between sloganeering campaigners and voters. Candidates or campaigners unintentionally (or deliberately) would canvass for, or solicit votes within 6m.
Electoral reform	a) The electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament was a bad law made by bad processes. "*The government's actions have cast a pall of illegitimacy over its political finance regime. The new framework is unfair and ineffectual in significant ways…*" [4]. b) There appears to be no oversight on the quality and content of political advertising. This has allowed voters to be exposed to messaging (e.g. on trucks, corflutes and flyers) that can mislead or deceive an elector in relation to the casting of a vote.	a) These bad laws have resulted in a loss of trust in the electoral process, and widespread perceptions of a 'stitch up'. The impact of a lack of trust, a lack of fairness, and a lack of integrity in the system cannot be underestimated. These feelings are what drive some vulnerable people towards fringe/extreme groups. This unfair 'stitch up' by the duopoly of the two major parties was one motivating factor for me to stand as an independent. b) Complete lack of integrity and trust in the conduct of elections. Breach of s329(1) of the Electoral Act.

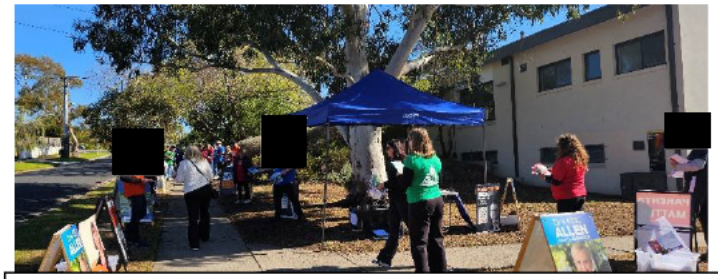
Use of money or capital	There were an excessive, wasteful and overwhelming number of campaigners (e.g. often more than 25-30 [redacted], and 15-20 Labor), corflutes and other political advertising material presented to voters. Some corflutes were illegally positioned, and one of our volunteer team collated photographs and reported to local councils. A truck displaying negative nasty slogans was repeatedly driven around polling booths (see example photos on page 5). The eyewatering amount of money spent has been documented [5]. It became apparent during pre-poll that some [redacted] campaigners were not who they claimed to be and were actually paid recruits.	The excessive use of money or capital can overwhelm voters, distort perceptions, and undermine the democratic process. Paid or incentivised recruits pretending to be party supporters is disingenuous at least, and blatant lies at worst. The impact of a lack of trust, a lack of fairness, and a lack of integrity in the system cannot be underestimated.
Threats of interference	a) I saw some people at Malvern wearing yellow vests similar to AEC colours. At the time I was confused and assumed they *were* AEC officials. I later learned [6] that these yellow vests were likely attempting to mislead or deceive an elector in relation to the casting of a vote, and potentially attempting to interfere with the electoral process. b) I was surprised with the excessive numbers, and shocked at the intense behaviours from many [redacted] campaigners at pre-poll. Several times at Ashwood and Ashburton I saw children (age under 18) campaigning in [redacted] shirts. I have since learned [7] that many [redacted] campaigners were not who they claimed to be, and were in fact recruits from an extreme, non-voting, misogynistic, religious cult called the Plymouth Brethren.	a) Breach of s329(1) of the Electoral Act. Loss of trust in the electoral process. The impact of a lack of trust, a lack of fairness, and a lack of integrity in the system cannot be underestimated. b) The impact of a lack of trust, a lack of fairness, and a lack of integrity in the system cannot be underestimated. The ultimate impact may have been voters seeing through the [redacted] party's deliberate, well-funded, and highly co-ordinated attempt at coercion, manipulation, and deception. The results speak for themselves. Australians have rejected [redacted] in record numbers. As the saying goes: the electorate usually gets it right. But we cannot rely on people to always make the 'right' decision. The system must be designed to protect the democratic process.

References

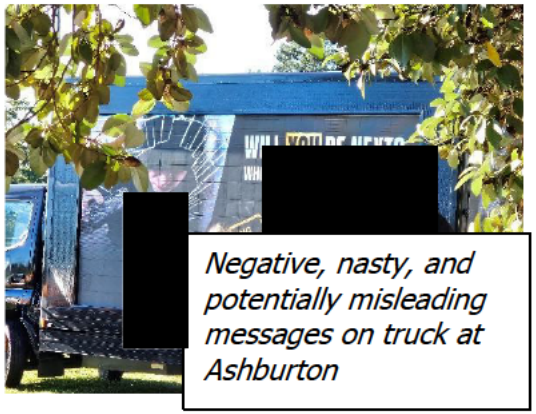
[redacted]

Example Photos

'Corridors of coercion': Malvern (left) view of only one third of what voters were forced to walk through to reach booth entrance. Ashburton (above right) spilling into carpark.



'Hill of harassment' at Ashwood: Looking up (above) and down (below right). Voters approached in car park, on both paths, then forced to walk uphill through more campaigners to booth entrance.



Negative, nasty, and potentially misleading messages on truck at Ashburton

Some examples of illegally posted signs around Ashburton and Ashwood.

Oakleigh: A much better layout providing a more relaxed, democratic, voter-centric vibe.

Suggested Solutions

The above observations/problems are interlinked, and need to be addresses systemically.

The electoral system should be there to FACILTATE (i.e. to make easier) the voting process FOR not AGAINST the VOTERS. It should not be exploitable by the campaigners, candidates or infiltrating others.

The impact of a lack of trust, a lack of fairness, and a lack of integrity in the voting system cannot be underestimated. These feelings are what drive some vulnerable people towards fringe/extreme groups, with the potential for with terrible individual and community consequences.

Electoral Aspect	Suggested Solutions
Polling booth physical layout	Give AEC officials capacity and powers to take control of polling booth entrances with: • The 6m zone extended to 20-30m. • The physical layout structured in accordance with the ballot paper. The ballot draw was double randomly selected with a transparent process and can be used as a standard against which the layout is assessed. The order of campaigners should follow the order of candidates on the ballot. • Allow space for a maximum of 2 campaigners/signs in each position of ballot order. • Use basic tools to help voters safely queue e.g. bollards, signs, ropes. • Use ground markings (if possible) to clearly show boundaries. • Post signs at entrance area listing basic 'rules' to avoid confusion and potential argument • Provide dog parking station and bike racks Chisholm specific: • Stop use of Ashburton Scout Hall as a pre-poll booth • Replace Ashburton with another location nearer Glen Waverley or Wheelers Hill to provide greater access for residents living in the east of electorate.

Campaigner behaviour, safety & security	Systems drive behaviour. If the above controlled environment is implemented, human behaviour will be affected, and the likelihood for tension will reduce. In addition to the physical layout solutions: • Roster for supervisors to monitor behaviour of campaigners external of the polling booth. • Roster should include people drawn from each campaign team to help minimise bias. • Implement a campaigner 'code of conduct' system that includes training on behavioural expectations, and can be managed by campaign teams with report to, and audit by, AEC. • Ensure campaigners are who they say they are. No paid recruits or infiltrating extreme cults pretending to be genuine volunteers. Consider a campaigner 'registration' system that can be managed by campaign teams with report to, and audit by, AEC. • Engage police or security staff to have regular walk around (worst case).
Electoral laws, money & interference	World events are showing a lack of trust in democracy, and an increase in autocracy and dictatorial governance. Now is the time for Australia to fully safeguard our precious, and fragile, democratic processes. I would suggest following recommendations from others who are more expert in this field: • The Australia Institute https://australiainstitute.org.au/post/the-election-exposed-weaknesses-in-australian-democracy-but-the-next-parliament-can-fix-them/ • The Australian Democracy Network https://www.ourdemocracy.com.au/the-framework/

End of [redacted] submission

Thank you for the opportunity to submit

Please help protect our democracy